

D253

Values-Based Leadership

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A new manager at a 40-person accounting office, who recently earned an MBA, tells his team that honesty matters most to him. The office is moving to a hybrid schedule next month. Which action best turns that value into daily behavior?

- A. Waiting until the hybrid move settles before acting on his values.
- B. Putting “honesty” on a poster in the break room.
- C. Sharing bad news openly and admitting and correcting his own mistakes, even when it is uncomfortable.
- D. Reminding the team often that he is an honest person.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A software company's website lists work-life balance as a core value. Managers praise and promote engineers who answer messages at midnight, and those who log off at 6 p.m. are passed over. The company has offices in three cities. Which values are actually shaping the culture?

- A. Differences in local culture among the three offices.
- B. No values at all; culture comes only from pay.
- C. The enacted values, rewarding constant availability, which override the stated value.
- D. Work-life balance, because the official statement defines the culture.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A leader wants to close the gap between the company's stated value of “customer first” and how people actually behave. Which step targets the enacted values most directly?

- A. Hang “customer first” posters in every office.
- B. Fire anyone who puts the customer second even once.
- C. Rewrite the values statement in stronger language.
- D. Change what is measured and rewarded, such as adding customer-outcome measures to reviews and promotions.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

At a hospital lab with 25 technicians, a junior tech notices a labeling error but stays quiet because the last person who raised a concern was mocked in a staff meeting. The lab recently bought new analyzers. What should the lab leader build first?

- A. Stricter penalties for anyone who makes an error.
- B. An anonymous reporting box as the only channel.
- C. More training on the new analyzers.
- D. Psychological safety: thank people who raise concerns, follow up visibly, and stop ridicule.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which leader behavior most weakens psychological safety?

- A. Publicly criticizing a team member who reports a mistake.
- B. Asking the quietest person for input first.
- C. Admitting her own mistakes in team meetings.
- D. Holding team members to high performance standards.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A plant manager who values both loyalty and safety learns that a supervisor, a friend of 20 years, skipped a required lockout step. No one was hurt. The plant just passed an ISO audit. Which response best reflects values-based leadership?

- A. Take no action, since the plant just passed its audit.
- B. Let it go to protect the friendship.
- C. Address it directly and apply the safety standard as for anyone else, while treating him with respect and explaining why.
- D. Fire him immediately without a conversation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A team lead at a 60-person nonprofit spends most of her week removing obstacles for her staff, asking what they need to grow, and sharing credit for wins. The nonprofit's budget rose 10% this year. Which leadership approach is this?

- A. Laissez-faire leadership.
- B. Servant leadership.
- C. Transactional leadership.
- D. Autocratic leadership.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A manager motivates staff mainly by setting clear targets, paying bonuses when they are met, and applying penalties when they are missed. Which approach is this?

- A. Transactional leadership.
- B. Transformational leadership.
- C. Servant leadership.
- D. Authentic leadership, since rewards always reflect values.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A hospital system with 11 clinics is planning for the next five years. The leadership team has a strong record of meeting budgets. Rather than betting on one forecast, the CEO asks for several plausible futures and a plan for each. What is this practice, and what is its main purpose?

- A. SWOT analysis.
- B. Scenario planning, to be ready to respond whichever future unfolds.
- C. Forecasting, to identify the single most likely future.
- D. Annual budgeting.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A leader using scenario planning decides that one scenario, the sudden loss of a key funder, is unlikely. What should she do with it?

- A.** Plan only for the best case to keep morale high.
- B.** Keep it, set warning signs to watch, and prepare a contingency response.
- C.** Drop it, since only likely scenarios need plans.
- D.** Assign it an exact probability and plan only if it exceeds 50%.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A restaurant manager whose team won a city award values growth for her staff. She wants to set a goal for next quarter. Which goal best links that value to a measurable outcome?

- A.** Raise sales 15% by March 31.
- B.** Win the city award again.
- C.** Help the team grow.
- D.** Each server completes one cross-training shift in the kitchen by March 31.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

An analyst who ranks honesty and family as her top personal values is offered a promotion at a firm with a new downtown office. The role requires frequent weekend travel and pressure to present client results in a misleadingly positive light. What does values-based thinking suggest she do first?

- A.** Compare the role's demands with her values and weigh the fit before deciding.
- B.** Refuse any role that involves any travel at all.
- C.** Accept because the new downtown office is appealing.
- D.** Accept for the title and pay, and adjust later.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A new manager at a 40-person accounting office, ~~who recently earned an MBA~~, tells his team that honesty matters most to him. ~~The office is moving to a hybrid schedule next month.~~ Which action best turns that value into daily behavior?

Target word: behavior that enacts the value **Decides:** Values show in consistent, costly actions.

A	Camouflage	The schedule change does not decide when values apply.
B	Dropped element	A display with no behavior behind it.
C	Correct	Visible, consistent behavior makes the value real.
D	Confusion set	Stating a value is espousing it, not enacting it.

2. Answer C Concept 2

A software company's website lists work-life balance as a core value. Managers praise and promote engineers who answer messages at midnight, and those who log off at 6 p.m. are passed over. ~~The company has offices in three cities.~~ Which values are actually shaping the culture?

Target word: which values drive culture **Decides:** What gets rewarded.

A	Camouflage	Location is not what the stem shows driving behavior.
B	Absolute language	Culture reflects many signals, including recognition and promotion.
C	Correct	Promotion decisions signal what truly matters.
D	Inverted operation	Espoused values lose when rewards contradict them.

3. Answer D Concept 2 · transfer

A leader wants to close the gap between the company's stated value of "customer first" and how people actually behave. Which step targets the enacted values most directly?

Target word: reverse: from gap to fix **Decides:** Enacted values follow rewards and measures.

A	Dropped element	No change in incentives or behavior.
B	Absolute language	Harsh zero-tolerance rules breed fear rather than aligned behavior.
C	Inverted operation	Works on the espoused side, not the enacted side.
D	Correct	Aligning rewards with the value changes behavior.

4. Answer D Concept 3

At a hospital lab ~~with 25 technicians~~, a junior tech notices a labeling error but stays quiet because the last person who raised a concern was mocked in a staff meeting. ~~The lab recently bought new analyzers.~~ What should the lab leader build first?

Target word: leader's first priority **Decides:** Fear from how past concerns were treated.

A	Inverted operation	Raises fear and silence.
B	Adjacent category	May help, but works around the fear instead of repairing the culture.
C	Camouflage	The equipment is not why the tech stayed silent.
D	Correct	People speak up when speaking up is safe.

5. Answer A Concept 3 • transfer

Which leader behavior most weakens psychological safety?

Target word: reverse: find the harmful behavior **Decides:** Punishing candor.

A	Correct	Teaches everyone that speaking up is risky.
B	Adjacent category	Invites voice rather than suppressing it.
C	Inverted operation	Models that errors can be discussed safely.
D	Confusion set	High standards and safety can coexist.

6. Answer C Concept 4

A plant manager who values both loyalty and safety learns that a supervisor, a friend of 20 years, skipped a required lockout step. No one was hurt. ~~The plant just passed an ISO audit.~~ Which response best reflects values-based leadership?

Target word: response to a values conflict **Decides:** Safety standard vs. personal loyalty.

A	Camouflage	A past audit does not excuse a current violation.
B	Dropped element	Drops the safety value entirely.
C	Correct	Consistent standards plus respectful dialogue honor both values.
D	Absolute language	Ignores respect and fair process.

7. Answer B Concept 5

A team lead ~~at a 60-person nonprofit~~ spends most of her week removing obstacles for her staff, asking what they need to grow, and sharing credit for wins. ~~The nonprofit's budget rose 10% this year.~~ Which leadership approach is this?

Target word: leadership approach **Decides:** Followers' needs and growth come first.

A	Adjacent category	Laissez-faire leaders are hands-off; she is highly engaged.
B	Correct	Serving and developing others is the core of the approach.
C	Confusion set	Transactional leaders trade rewards for results.
D	Inverted operation	Autocrats centralize control rather than serve.

8. Answer A Concept 5 • transfer

A manager motivates staff mainly by setting clear targets, paying bonuses when they are met, and applying penalties when they are missed. Which approach is this?

Target word: reverse: from behavior to approach **Decides:** Rewards exchanged for performance.

A	Correct	Leadership as an exchange of rewards and penalties.
B	Confusion set	Transformational leaders inspire through vision.
C	Inverted operation	Servant leaders focus on followers' growth, not trades.
D	Absolute language	Rewards do not automatically express values.

9. Answer B Concept 6

A hospital system ~~with 11 clinics~~ is planning for the next five years. ~~The leadership team has a strong record of meeting budgets.~~ Rather than betting on one forecast, the CEO asks for several plausible futures and a plan for each. What is this practice, and what is its main purpose?

Target word: name and purpose **Decides:** Several futures, a plan for each.

A	Adjacent category	SWOT maps current strengths and conditions, not alternative futures.
B	Correct	Preparation across futures, not prediction.
C	Inverted operation	The CEO explicitly rejects a single forecast.
D	Camouflage	Answers the budget record, not the practice described.

10. Answer B Concept 6 · transfer

A leader using scenario planning decides that one scenario, the sudden loss of a key funder, is unlikely. What should she do with it?

Target word: treatment of an unlikely scenario **Decides:** The goal is readiness, not probability.

A	Dropped element	Leaves the organization unprepared for any downside.
B	Correct	High-impact scenarios matter even when unlikely.
C	Inverted operation	Turns scenario planning back into forecasting.
D	Adjacent category	A forecasting approach, not scenario planning.

11. Answer D Concept 7

A restaurant manager ~~whose team won a city award~~ values growth for her staff. She wants to set a goal for next quarter. Which goal best links that value to a measurable outcome?

Target word: values-based goal **Decides:** Tied to staff growth and measurable.

A	Adjacent category	Measurable, but not tied to the value of staff growth.
B	Camouflage	Answers the past award, not the value.
C	Dropped element	Names the value but cannot be measured.
D	Correct	Specific, measurable, time-bound, and tied to staff growth.

12. Answer A Concept 8

An analyst who ranks honesty and family as her top personal values is offered a promotion ~~at a firm with a new downtown office.~~ The role requires frequent weekend travel and pressure to present client results in a misleadingly positive light. What does values-based thinking suggest she do first?

Target word: first step in the decision **Decides:** Role demands clash with stated values.

A	Correct	Values alignment is the core test in a values-based decision.
B	Absolute language	The issue is fit and degree, not a blanket rule.
C	Camouflage	The office does not decide values fit.
D	Dropped element	Leaves her values out of the decision.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	6	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	4	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Values made visible in behavior	A value becomes real only through consistent, observable behavior, especially when it is costly.	Thinking that stating or posting a value puts it into practice.	“Which action best turns the value into daily behavior?”
2	Espoused vs. enacted values	Culture follows what leaders reward, tolerate, and model (enacted values), not what the values statement says (espoused values).	Fixing a say-do gap by rewriting the statement.	An official value contradicted by who gets praised or promoted.
3	Psychological safety and a culture of care	People speak up about problems only when they expect respect, not ridicule or punishment; leaders build this by how they respond to concerns and mistakes.	Responding to silence with stricter penalties, or confusing safety with low standards.	Someone stays quiet because of how a past concern was treated.
4	Resolving values conflicts	When values collide, act on the higher-priority principle consistently, explain the reasoning, and treat the people involved with respect.	Letting a personal relationship override a safety or integrity standard, or acting harshly without dialogue.	A friend or loyal employee breaks a standard.
5	Servant vs. transactional leadership	Servant leaders put followers' growth and needs first; transactional leaders exchange rewards and penalties for performance; transformational leaders inspire toward a shared vision.	Mixing up servant and transformational, or calling bonus-driven management servant leadership.	What the leader spends time on: removing obstacles, setting deals, or inspiring vision.
6	Scenario planning	Scenario planning prepares responses to several plausible futures rather than predicting one; unlikely but high-impact scenarios stay in the plan.	Treating it as forecasting the most likely outcome.	“Several plausible futures” and a plan for each.
7	Values-based goal setting	A values-based goal ties a stated value to a specific, measurable, time-bound action.	Writing a vague value statement as a goal, or a measurable goal unrelated to the value.	A value plus a request for a goal.
8	Person-organization values fit	Before a major career decision, compare the role's demands with personal values; poor fit predicts stress and disengagement.	Deciding on title or pay alone, or treating any conflict as automatically disqualifying.	An offer whose demands clash with stated personal values.

Course scope (public description): Values-Based Leadership guides students to learn by reflection, design, and scenario planning. Through a combination of theory, reflection, value alignment, and practice, the course helps students examine and understand values-based leadership and explore foundations in creating a culture of care. In this course, students are given the opportunity to identify and define their personal values through an assessment and reflection process. Students then evaluate business cases to practice mapping the influence of values on their own leadership. In this course, students also participate in scenario planning, where they can practice implementing their values in their daily routine (i.e., behaviors) and then in a leadership setting. The course illustrates how values-driven leadership is used in goal setting as well as problem-solving at an organizational

level. There are no prerequisites for this course.